

Moonsea Rising - 20240211

The Battle of the Scions

As the party looks down at the dig site, they notice some order in the chaos. Several guards around the entrance to the dig wall have a white hand mark on their faces. And, of particular interest, the guards all seem to be distracted by some kind of ritual bloodsport in a ring nearby. At the western gate to the site, a captain looms rather imposingly inside the gate. Ringing the site is a ten-foot pallisade.

Harken suggests they open the gate the boars are kept in, perhaps causing some disarray in the orcish ranks as they try to recapture their food supply. Lennox, interestingly, recognizes the white claw marking as being specific to the White Claw tribe. He knows they're fierce enemies of the Red Eye tribe.

As they're discussing options, a small detachment of orcs and goblins leave on patrol down the road. Lennox and Taevyn counsel for cutting them off. They try to cut them off, but the goblins' fine senses pick them ahead of time. One manages to flee back to the camp before the ambush, but the party doesn't think he saw specifically who the ambushers were. Harken starts trying to desecrate the corpse with Eye symbology, and thinks they should continue to try and draw out the orcs. Lennox and Beitris think the orcs are equally or more likely to hole up in the camp, and prepare for an attack. At Lennox' suggestion, Beitris attempts to create a false trail leading away from the ambush site.

They head back to the camp, which is abuzz with activity. The orcish commander is talking to the goblin, and barks something at the group of Bruleicos, who muster up near the gate. Several of the orcs join them, as well as one of the larger orcs, and they depart up the road. Assuming the timing is getting tight, based on the speed the patrol is leaving, they make a plan to further sow chaos.

Harken gives Taevyn his invisibility ring, and he clambers up and over the pallisade. Heading towards the pen, the pigs scent him and start trying to locate him. He circles the pen cautiously, with the pigs tracking his movements as he goes. The orc commander notices, and watches the gate. Taevyn draws a dagger, invisibly, throwing it away to try and distract the commander. He hears the sound, and, grumbling turns in that direction, calling out.

Taevyn opens the gate, and the pigs immediately exit the gate, following him, snorting and snuffling. Discarding the plan to set a fire, he sprints for the front gate, with the pigs in pursuit.

Lirael sees all this, and assumes from their behavior that pigs have scented Taevyn. Summoning her magicks, she turns into a massive boar. Bellowing, she charges the orcs pursuing the pigs, who turn and follow her, enthralled with the Boar God in their midst. They'll fall on and slaughter the guards chasing them, and race into the camp, snorting and screaming. The orcs look around and see their dinner being lead by a huge, frothing boar. They reach frantically for their weapons.

Taevyn looks twice, and heads for the braziers, unaware for the moment that Boarael is his elven companion. Lennox vaults the wall, axe glinting in the low light.

Taevyn flips the brazier as two of the massive orcs move to attack Boarael, both missing her in her battle form, as does one of the boworcs. She gores the nearest orc, hitting him with her tusks.

Lennox lands, smashing the nearby orc with his axe, killing him on the spot. Looking around, he races towards the next foe. Harken scrambles and awkwardly flops over the wall. Taevyn wall-kicks atop the embankment over the doorway, and lashes out with his rapier at the guard, killing him. He also charges the nearest other.

One of the White Claw orcs manages to slash Boarael with his scimitar, scoring her hide. Beitris manages to surmount the pallisade slightly more gracefully than Harken before her.

What greets her is a scene of bedlam. Lennox and Taevyn grinning, covered in blood; Boarael at the head of a column of pigs and the orcs swarming around her. One of the orcs manages to cut her again, though her form is tough. Harken uses his psychic powers to fling a bunch of detritus at the nearest guard, knocking him from his perch and killing him. Taevyn slashes at the next guard along the wall, leaving him bleeding and near death.

Beitris summons her spiritual weapon, which lashes out at the White Claw attacking Boarael. She roars to the other boars to kill them all. Lashing out, she savagely gores the White Claw again as the boars rush from their grisly meal to the attack, savaging the remaining orcs. The White Claw lashes out at her, but his wounds are grievous and he cannot connect.

Lennox swings his axe, flinging the guard through the air in smaller pieces. Harken blasts another with his psychic blast, killing it. Boarael and the pigs mop up the remaining orcs as Taevyn clears the walls.

As the boars feast, Lirael moves off towards the ruins entrance before dropping her disguise. Beitris heals her, as, despite the battle form, she's still fairly frail. As the glow surrounds her, her wounds close and she thanks Beitris gratefully.

The Temple of Xul'Jarak

Descending into the earth, the party finds what the miners found -- an ancient buried temple. Scattered through the room are dead orcs. They have apparently been crushed to death. A teleportation circle sits in the south of the room, and four sarcophagi line the walls. Lennox has heard stories of such circles aging their users, and suggests they speed up their search. The corridors are unusual, narrowing significantly at intervals and with blind corners that harm lines of sight and travel. They find another room with a long table, with a number of dead White Claw orcs, who look like they have been frightened to death.

A book sits on the end of the table, and Lirael examines but does not touch it, casting detect magic. As the spell takes effect, the temperature in the room drops. The book emanates unholy magicks, as several shadowy figures flow out of the walls.

One reaches out to touch Beitris as void energies flow through her. Her shadow appears to be yanked by the creature. She raises her holy symbol and the room fills with sunlight. The shadows

are wracked with the holy light, and the one that struck Beitris is dissipated into nothingness. The remaining shadows all turn towards her, slashing at her with their claws.

Lennox swings at the nearest one, cutting through it, though it seems immaterial. He swings at another, slashing it though it remains. Lirael fires a ray of frost at the shadow on Beitris, dissipating it as well. Harken flings a bunch of junk at the nearest one and retreats behind Beitris. Taevyn tumbles through the shadow, which scores him with his claw, chilling him. He screams out to the others not to touch the shadows. He pokes the rapier through it, seemingly without effect. He adopts his parry stance, looking worried.

The shadow near Lennox swipes him with its claw, weakening the large man. Some much worse creature with glowing eyes floats out through the walls, attacking Lennox and Lirael. Lennox has the hand pass through him, as does Lirael, and both feel the life force being drained away. Beitris summons her god's power again, searing the undead and destroying the two shadows.

Lennox swings his axe, which passes through creature thrice, damaging it, but not killing it. Lirael shifts again, choosing the unicorn this time. She spears at the incorporeal spirit with her horn, but misses due to the prior attacks.

Harken continues to mentally fling things at the spirits, to limited effect. Taevyn sways, attempting to use his normal parlor tricks on the undead, but they are generally unmoved by the silliness. The thing in the corner attacks Liraelicorn, hitting her twice and draining her again.

Beitris disrupts the nearly dead dead creature, causing it to dissolve. She moves forward, ready to help her companions. Lennox moves around the equine Liraelicorn, swinging his axe at the remaining creature. Liraelicorn tries to stick it with her horn, but has no success. Harken continues his psychic assault, as Taevyn continues his ineffectual pokery. The wraith continues trying to drain the life out of Lennox. Beitris disrupts the last wraith, bringing it far closer to the eternal void, but it fights on.

Lennox weakening continues to swing his axe, showing defiance unto death. Liraelicorn finally spears it with her horn, the creature shrieking as the spirit magicks wrack it. Taevyn slashes desperately, and the wraith finally succumbs to the onslaught.

Beitris casts restoration on Lennox and Lirael, removing the enervation from them. She also heals the party, though she, like Lirael is running low on energy for the day. Lirael attempts to take the book, but it and its plinth are both immovable. She notes that it's not a spell book, but rather a list of names. The most recent being General Sivelous Tuskclaw, and the others clearly being orcish or even more alien.

She notes that the book is clearly old, and the orcs worship some weird gods, and that the book is likely related to the undead in this temple. But without time to delve further, she recommends they find their quarry and flee. Taevyn looks to Beitris for direction on proceeding. She says they should at least try the door at the south of the room. Both Harken and Taevyn are quite certain the door isn't trapped, so Taevyn attempts to pick the locks. Despite feeling quite confident, he's unable to open the door.

Checking the east and west passages, they find levers just south of the room. Coordinating by shouts, Lennox and Taevyn pull the levers in both corridors. The locked door swings open, revealing a massive chamber.

On the southern is a huge dais, on which stands a glowing, faceless, tentacled humanoid, whose visage gives of a sense of nameless dread. A pile of dozens of dead orcs lies in the room. A ornately dressed military orc lies dead on a silver disc, and a human lies dead on a similar gold one. The human appears to be Argens Brule.

In alcoves along the walls, the five remaining scions are tied up and gagged. On the dais is a large chest, whose handle is a femur continually dripping some kind of fluid.

The humanoid speaks in their minds. "One shall ask; another shall pay."